Arakan relative independence and the creation of a Muslim National Area, in exchange for their contribution to the war effort. But, as in many other cases, they went on to commit a huge historical error and reneged on this promise once the Japanese were defeated.[59]

In 1947 some Rohingyas formed their own army and sought the incorporation of northern Arakan into the newly created East Pakistan,[60] now Bangladesh. This initiative failed, but after Burma achieved its own independence in 1948, some Arakanese Muslims went on to petition the Constituent Assembly in Rangoon for the integration of Maungdaw and Buthidaung districts into East Pakistan.[61] This was to have dire long-term consequences. It drove the Burmese authorities to regard the Muslim population of Arakan as hostile to the new regime[62] and to see them as outsiders whose loyalty lay with a different state. These events helped create a belief that only Buddhists could really be part of the new state, an attitude reinforced by the attempt of the Burmese Communist Party to overthrow the new state after 1948.

The other side of the liberation struggle in this period was even more complex. The Burmese Independence Army (BIA), led by the 'thirty comrades' (including General Aung San), was originally formed to help the Japanese against the British, and during 1942–5 mostly fought for the Japanese,[63] especially against the Chinese troops that were supporting British and American efforts to keep open a supply line to China. In addition, British accounts of the war make frequent references to local acts of sabotage[64] so, as with the Indian National Army, it was clear that many Burmese nationalists took the view that the Japanese were useful as a tool to weaken the British. Aung San had gone to Japan in 1941 and was made chief of staff when the Japanese declared Burma independent in 1943.[65]

By 1944, increased Japanese repression and violence led many of the independence leaders to see the British as the lesser of two evils, especially as it was clear that the Japanese were losing the wider war.[66] Aung San started to negotiate with the British and the independence movement subsequently switched sides and took part in the 27 March 1945 uprising against the Japanese. To Burmese nationalists this was originally 'Resistance Day' and later became 'Armed Forces Day', representing a key step on the road to an independent Burma. To others it was an opportunistic shift of allegiance when it was clear the Japanese were beaten.[67] But the